‘Did you hope to win the race?’
‘I had no such hope. I only tried to do my best and I am happy that I succeeded beyond my expectations.’

‘In your hour of victory, do you have any messages for your country?’
‘Only to say: my country, your son has done his duty towards you. May every citizen do his duty to his motherland.’

‘ *What are your impressions about the people of this country?’*
‘Their love and good wishes inspired me to win.’ (This reply was just a formality.)

‘Did you have a chance to run with these athletes before?’
‘No, this is the first time that I have had the honour.’

My win was a historic event, particularly significant because this was the first time that an Indian athlete had won a gold medal at the Commonwealth Games. My victory had put India on the sports map of the world.

When I first arrived in Cardiff I was a nonentity. Today, I was treated like a celebrity. Our high commissioner to the Court of St James, Mrs Vijaylakshmi Pandit, had watched my win from the VIP enclosure, and she came up to congratulate me after the victory ceremony. When I saw her approach, escorted by our manager Ashwini Kumar, I wondered who that lady with ‘bob-cut’ hair was. Then we were introduced and I was very happy to meet the sister of our prime minister, Pandit Nehru, whom I had the privilege of meeting after I had returned from Tokyo. She embraced me and remarked that I had raised India’s honour and the nation was proud of me. I was uplifted by such warm felicitations. Then she told me that Panditji had sent a message asking what I would like as a reward for bringing such glory to India. I requested that a national holiday be declared on the day I landed in India—a wish that the prime minister happily granted! The Duke of Edinburgh had also come up to greet me. He had watched me winning the race and said, ‘I greatly appreciate Milkha Singh’s style of running.’

That night we met sportsmen from all the other Commonwealth nations. We congratulated each other and talked of this and that. The next